13

The Aftermath

RAJIV GANDHI, in his election speech of 19 November 1984 at the Boat Club in New Delhi had justified the anti-Sikh pogrom as a natural outcome of public anger generated by an earth-shaking event. What he did not realize was that sometimes minor tremors can also lead to a major earthquake. That is precisely what happened in Punjab in the decade that followed that speech. The felling of thousands of 'small' trees during Operation Blue Star and the anti-Sikh pogrom of November 1984 was bound to cause tremors in Punjab. The killings of thousands of innocent Sikhs were also bound to generate intense anger among an entire community, as getting 'very angry' over the killing of a loved one cannot be the prerogative of a single family or party.

Sikhs comprise about 1.75 per cent of India's population, and since they had hardly any voting potential outside Punjab, some politicians thought they could easily be ignored and pushed about. And that was what happened. As a result, Punjab's industrial and economic growth, already stalled due to the impact of Op-1 launched in 1978, suffered a huge setback. Earlier, the whole of India belonged to the Sikhs, and vice-versa. But following the November 1984 pogrom, an entire insecure generation of Sikh youth got bottled up in Punjab. And the next generation got busy, either enjoying life by living far beyond their means or by seeking greener pastures in countries like Canada. Many more, who were left behind in the race for life, started cutting themselves off from the realities of the world by taking refuge in drugs.